field,' he says. 'Just focus on the bowling.' There is no fine leg. It's the first time I've bowled to a field with no fine leg. Do I say anything? No, I say nothing. He must know best; he's the England captain, I think. It's like the broken wrist on that black ice or the sick in Neil Mortimer's bed. I know something is up, but I choose to say nothing. Better just to keep schtum and try to do what I'm told. The over is a disaster. Seventeen runs are leaked off my first ever six balls in Test cricket, most of them down to the eerily vacated spot at fine leg. I can't remember if I've ever conceded 17 runs in an over in my life.

As is becoming our general mode of communication, Nasser walks over to me for the next one. I'm half expecting him to take the ball out of my hands, send me to the boundary to deal with a fate far worse than Bay 13, my own shame, but he says instead, 'I got that wrong,' looking at the ball and not at me. 'Don't worry about that one.' He resets the field, this time much more something I am accustomed to seeing. I settle, breathe out, set off and start again. Cricket always gives you a chance to reset and start again. By the third over, I'm beginning to mould into the hum of Lord's a little, finding it less stressful, my line and length corrected, blending into the sweet spell of doing what I can do. Mark Vermeulen is facing me. I run in, calmer, through my usual process, the grass beneath me more accommodating than it had been even five minutes ago, a wind behind me, feeling the slope, the gentle uphill that ties Lord's to Burnley and the creek. I'm into my stride, briefly sighting my watch on my left wrist that will one day be replaced by a wristband. I follow the line of it and the ball does too. Vermeulen has guessed the wrong line and plays inside of it. It goes past his outside edge and then there's a sound. It's the sound of bails leaving stumps. It's not a clatter or a smash, but more of a tick, like a godsent swish. It's telling me that that is the first one; my debut Test wicket.

They are 133/6 and I am still searching. I'm surprising myself with how fun I'm finding being in the middle of it all. It's like being Boris Becker, that beautiful stillness and control when the ball is in my hand. The middle of it all being the calmest place to be. Heath Streak is facing me and I find the ball I'm looking for – the magic one I've bowled to Mohammad Yousuf and all those club cricketers. I know it is that one as it leaves my fingers, just like Mike Watkinson said I would. Streak's eyes light up to flick it off leg stump, the illusion telling him the ball is slanting down the leg side,